

The Uncanny (Das Unheimliche)

Extract

Sigmund Freud

1919

[. . .] In the first place, if psycho-analytic theory is correct in maintaining that every affect belonging to an emotional impulse, whatever its kind, is transformed, if it is repressed, into anxiety, then among instances of frightening things there must be one class in which the frightening element can be shown to be something repressed which recurs. This class of
5 frightening things would then constitute the uncanny; and it must be a matter of indifference whether what is uncanny was originally frightening or whether it carried some other affect. In the second place, if this is indeed the secret nature of the uncanny, we can understand why linguistic usage has extended das Heimliche [homely] into its opposite das Unheimliche; for this uncanny is in reality nothing new or alien, but something which is familiar and old—es-
10 tablished in the mind and which has become alienated from it only through the process of repression. This reference to the factor of repression enables us, furthermore, to [. . .] the uncanny as something which ought to have remained hidden but has come to light.

It only remains for us to test our new hypothesis on one or two more examples of the un-
canny.

15 Many people experience the feeling in the highest degree in relation to death and dead bodies, to the return of the dead, and to spirits and ghosts. [. . .] There is scarcely any other matter, however, upon which our thoughts and feelings have changed so little since the very earliest times, and in which discarded forms have been so completely preserved under a thin disguise, as our relation to death. [. . .] Since almost all of us still think as savages do on this topic, it
20 is no matter for surprise that the primitive fear of the dead is still so strong within us and always ready to come to the surface on any provocation. Most likely our fear still implies the old belief that the dead man becomes the enemy of his survivor and seeks to carry him off to share his new life with him. Considering our unchanged attitude towards death, we might rather inquire what has become of the repression, which is the necessary condition of a prim-
25 itive feeling recurring in the shape of something uncanny. But repression is there, too. All supposedly educated people have ceased to believe, officially that the dead can become visible as spirits, and have made any such appearances dependent on improbable and remote condi-
tions; their emotional attitude towards their dead, moreover, once a highly ambiguous and ambivalent one, has been toned down in the higher strata of the mind into an unambiguous
30 feeling of piety.

We have now only a few more remarks to add - for animism, magic and sorcery, the omnipo-
tence of thoughts, man's attitude to death, involuntary repetition and the castration-complex
comprise practically all the factors which turn something frightening into something un-
canny. [. . .]

35 Dismembered limbs, a severed head, a hand cut off at the wrist, feet which dance by them-
selves [. . .] all these have something peculiarly uncanny about them, especially when, as in

the last instance, they prove capable of independent activity in addition. As we already know, this kind of uncanniness springs from its proximity to the castration-complex. To some people the idea of being buried alive by mistake is the most uncanny thing of all. And yet
40 psycho-analysis has taught us that this terrifying phantasy is only a transformation of another phantasy which had originally nothing terrifying about it at all, but was filled with a certain lasciviousness —the phantasy, I mean, of intra-uterine existence.

There is one more point of general application which I should like to add, though, strictly speaking, it has been included in what has already been said about animism and modes of
45 working on the mental apparatus that have been surmounted; for I think it deserves special mention. This is that an uncanny effect is often and easily produced when the distinction between imagination and reality is effaced as when something that we have hitherto regarded as imaginary appears before us in reality, or when a symbol takes over the full functions of the thing it symbolizes, and so on. [. . .] In the middle of the isolation of war-time a number
50 of the English Strand Magazine fell into my hands; and, among other somewhat redundant matter, I read a story about a young married couple, who move into a furnished house in which there is a curiously shaped table with carvings of crocodiles on it. Towards evening an intolerable and very specific smell begins to pervade the house; they stumble over things in the dark; they seem to see a vague form gliding up the stairs—in short, we are given to
55 understand that the presence of the table causes ghostly crocodiles to haunt the place, or that the wooden monsters come to life in the dark, or something of the sort. It was a naïve enough story, but the uncanny feeling it produced was quite remarkable.

To conclude this collection of examples, which is certainly not complete, I will relate an instance taken from psycho-analytical experience; if it does not rest upon mere coincidence, it
60 furnishes a beautiful confirmation of our theory of the uncanny. It often happens that neurotic men declare that they feel there is something uncanny about the female genital organs. This unheimlich place, however, is the entrance to the former heim [home] of all human beings, to the place where each one of us lived once upon a time and in the beginning. There is a joking saying that: “Love is home-sickness”; and whenever a man dreams of a place or
65 a country and says to himself, still dreaming, “this place is familiar to me, I have been here before,” we may interpret the place as being his mother’s genitals or her body. In this case, too, then, the unheimlich is what was once heimisch, familiar; the prefix “un” is the token of repression.¹

¹Freud, Sigmund: Das Unheimliche. In: Imago, no. 5/6, 1919. I: The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud. Voloumen XVII: An Infantile Neurosis and other works. Translated by James Strachey. The Hogarth Press and The Institute of Psycho-Analysis, 1955, 1973. pp. 241-245.